

# Coral reef

Tropical coral reefs are among the richest and most colorful wildlife habitats on Earth. They are built up by simple animals—corals—living in partnership with microbes that use the energy of sunlight to make food. This allows corals to live in clear tropical waters that contain few of the plankton that support life in cooler oceans. They provide a home for an amazing variety of fish and other sea creatures.



## CORAL COLONIES

A coral is a creature resembling a sea anemone, with a crown of tentacles that it uses to catch small animals. Reef corals live in colonies where all the corals are linked to one another. Their transparent skin contains microscopic algae called zooxanthellae, which use solar energy to turn water and carbon dioxide into sugar.

### ◀ CORAL CROWN

*A close-up view of a coral shows the tentacles that trap tiny drifting animals.*

## ROCKY REEFS

Reef-building corals absorb lime from the water, and use it to build skeletons of limestone. When old corals die, new corals grow on their rocky remains. Over the centuries, the rock builds up to form a reef. Many reefs are quite small, but others are enormous—the Great Barrier Reef (below) off the coast of Australia is 1,430 miles (2,300 km) long.

**FACT!**

The food-making microbes that live in the tissues of reef corals are so small that there may be more than 2 million of them in a fragment of coral the size of your fingernail.

